

-
1. Evaluate whether or not the French government upheld the ideals of the Revolution during the period 1789 to 1794.

In your response you should do the following:

- Respond to the prompt with a historically defensible thesis or claim that establishes a line of reasoning.
- Describe a broader historical context relevant to the prompt.
- Support an argument in response to the prompt using at least four documents.
- Use at least one additional piece of specific historical evidence (beyond that found in the documents) relevant to an argument about the prompt.
- For at least two documents, explain how or why the document's point of view, purpose, historical situation, and/or audience is relevant to an argument.
- Demonstrate a complex understanding of a historical development related to the prompt through sophisticated argumentation and/or effective use of evidence.

Document 1

Source: Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen, ratified by the National Assembly of France, August 1789

“The National Assembly recognizes and proclaims, in the presence and under the auspices of the Supreme Being, the following rights of man and of the citizen:

1. Men are born and remain free and equal in rights. Social distinctions may be founded only upon the general good.
2. The aim of all political association is the preservation of the natural...rights of man. These rights are liberty, property, security, and resistance to oppression.
9. All persons are held innocent until they shall have been declared guilty. If arrest shall be deemed indispensable, all harshness not essential to the securing of the prisoner's person shall be severely repressed by law.
10. No one shall be harassed on account of his opinions, including his religious views.
11. The free communication of ideas and opinions is one of the most precious of the rights of man. Every citizen may, accordingly, speak, write, and print with freedom, but shall be responsible for such abuses of this freedom as shall be defined by law.”

Document 2

Source: Olympe de Gouges, female political activist, *Declaration of the Rights of Woman and the Female Citizen*, September 1791

“Woman, wake up! The call of reason is being heard throughout the whole universe. Discover your rights. The powerful empire of nature is no longer surrounded by prejudice, fanaticism, superstition, and lies. The flame of truth has dispersed all the clouds of folly and violation.

Having become free, man has become unjust to you, his companion. Oh, women, women! When will you cease to be blind? What advantage have you received from the Revolution? A more pronounced scorn, a more marked disdain.

[I urge you to] deploy all the energy of your character, and you will soon see these overbearing men, not groveling at your feet as servile adorers, but proud to share with you the treasures of the Supreme Being. Regardless of what barriers confront you, it is in your power to free yourselves. You have only to want to.”

Document 3

Source: The French Constitution, ratified by the National Assembly, September 1791

“The constitution guarantees as natural and civil rights:

1. that all citizens are admissible to offices and employments without any other distinction than that of virtues and talents;
2. that all taxes shall be borne equally by all citizens in proportion to their resources;
3. that like crimes shall be punished by like penalties without any distinction of persons.

The constitution guarantees likewise as natural and civil rights freedom to every man to come and go or remain without being arrested or detained except in accordance with the forms determined by the constitution.

[The constitution guarantees every man the right] to practice the religious faith which he accepts, freedom to citizens to assemble peaceably and without arms in accordance with police regulations.

Furthermore, the legislature may not make any law which interferes with or hinders the exercise of the natural and civil rights guaranteed by the present constitution.”

Document 4

Source: Berr Isaac Berr, Jewish-French merchant, “Letter of a Citizen to His Fellow Jews,” October 1791

“Gentlemen and dear brethren,

At length the day has come when the veil, by which we were kept in a state of humiliation, is lifted; at length we recover those rights which have been taken from us more than eighteen centuries ago. How much are we at this moment indebted to the mercy of the God of our forefathers! We are now, thanks to the Supreme Being and to the sovereignty of the nation, not only Men and Citizens, but we are Frenchmen!

The name of active citizen, which we have just obtained, is, without a doubt, the most precious title a man can possess in a free state. This title alone is not sufficient; we should possess also the necessary qualifications to fulfill the duties attached to it.... In these things we must absolutely appear simply as individuals, as Frenchmen, guided only by a true patriotism and by the general good of the nation. We must know how to risk our lives and fortunes for the defense of the country, to make ourselves useful to our fellow citizens, and to deserve their esteem and their friendship.”

Document 5

Source: Pierre Vergniaud, one of the leaders of the Girondins, a faction opposed to the Jacobins, speech to the French legislature, March 1793

“We go from crimes to pardons, from pardons to crimes. Numbers of citizens have begun to mistake treasonous insurrections for the great revolution of liberty.

We have witnessed the development of that strange system of liberty, in which we are told: ‘You are free; but think with us, or we will denounce you to the vengeance of the people. You are free, but bow down your head to the idol we worship, or we will denounce you to the vengeance of the people. You are free, but join us in persecuting the men whose integrity and intelligence we fear, or we will denounce you to the vengeance of the people.’ Citizens, we have reason to fear that the revolution will devour all its children and only [give rise to] despotism and the calamities which accompany it.”

Document 6

Source: Charlotte Corday, political activist, manifesto written before her assassination of the Jacobin leader Jean-Paul Marat, Paris, July 1793

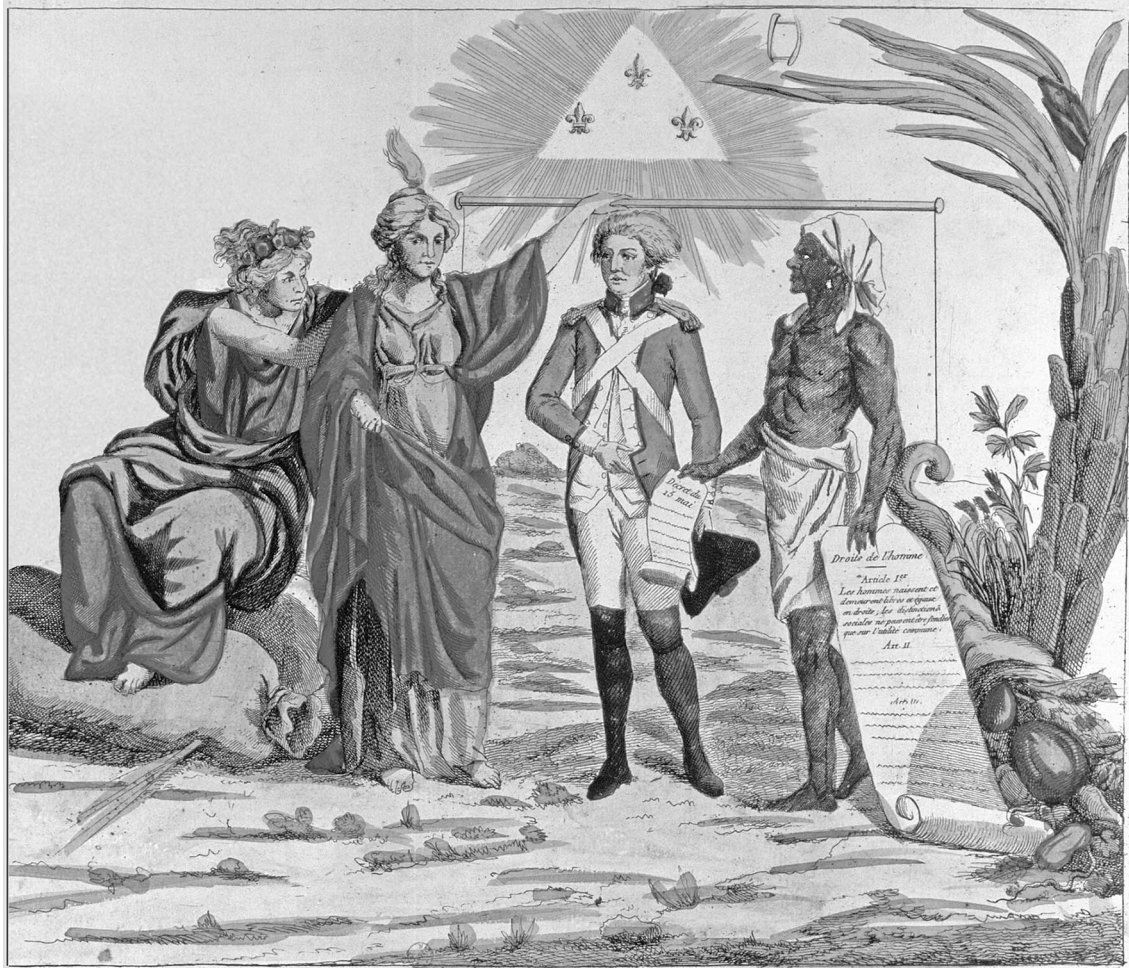
“Address to the French, the friends of law and of peace: How long, oh miserable Frenchmen, will you be pleased with disorder and divisions. Long enough and too long have some factious men, some wicked men placed the interest of their ambition in the place of the general good. Why, victims of their fury, do you destroy yourselves to establish their desire of tyranny over the ruins of France?

The factions explode on all sides; the Jacobins triumph by crime and oppression. Monsters drenched with our blood conduct their detestable conspiracies.

Already the angry inhabitants outside the capital march on Paris. Already the fire of discord and civil war inflames half of this vast state. There is still a means of extinguishing it, but the means must be prompt. The vilest of the wicked, Marat, whose name alone presents the image of all crime, when he falls under the avenging steel [of my blade], will shake the Jacobins and make Danton grow pale. Robespierre and those other brigands seated upon the bloody throne will be enveloped in the lightning of the avenging gods of humanity.”

Document 7

Source: Anonymous French artist, “All Mortals are Equal; it is not Birth but Virtue that Makes the Difference,” print created in response to the abolition of slavery in French colonies, 1794



Bibliothèque Nationale, Paris, France/Bridgeman Images

The female figure in the center represents Reason. The figure to the left represents Nature. The African man to the right is holding a copy of the Declaration of the Rights of Man and the Citizen.